



PRODUCT DESIGN INTERVIEW

Enhancing Instagram Stories

A PM case study on improving creator tools to drive story quality, viewer engagement, and long-term retention.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

What Are We Solving?

As the PM responsible for Instagram Stories, the goal is to **enhance the creator experience** — leading to higher story quality, stronger viewer engagement, and improved platform retention.

Creator Experience

Better tools = better stories

Viewer Engagement

More compelling content to watch

Platform Retention

Higher usage across Instagram



Prioritizing Retention Through Creators



Among Instagram's possible objectives — engagement, monetization, differentiation — **user retention** is the highest-leverage goal for Stories.

The strategic bet: **invest in creators first**. When creators have better tools, they produce better stories. Better stories attract more viewers. More viewers means higher retention and monetization upside for Instagram.

- ❑ Creator quality is a force multiplier — it benefits all three stakeholders simultaneously.

Three Stakeholders, One Ecosystem



Creators

Produce and post stories. Need powerful, frictionless tools to express themselves and grow their audience.



Viewers

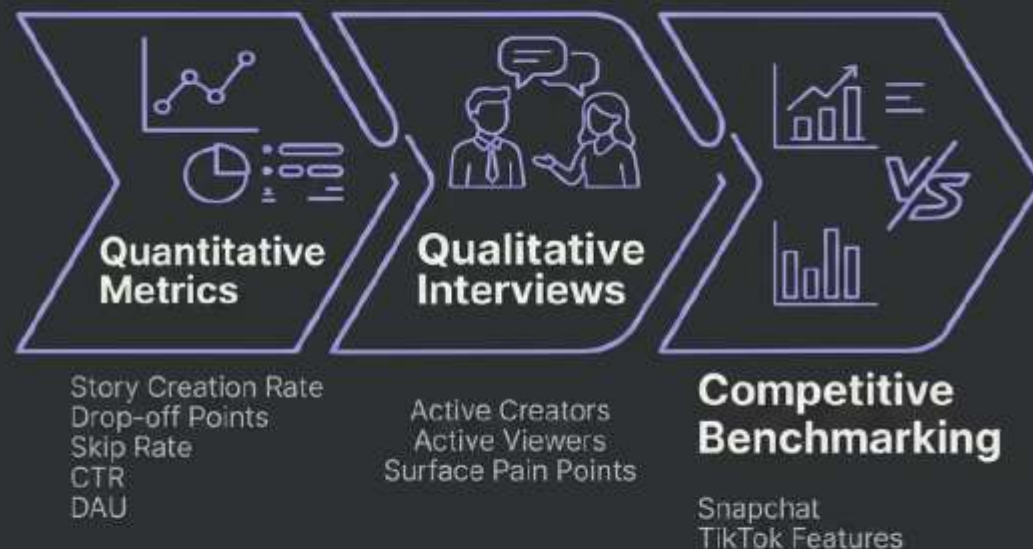
Consume and react to stories. Want fast-loading, engaging, and clear content that respects their time.



Instagram

Wants higher engagement, stronger retention, and expanded monetization opportunities across the platform.

How We'll Uncover the Real Problems



Triangulating Insights

Before proposing any solution, we need a complete picture of where Stories breaks down. Quantitative data reveals *what* is happening; qualitative research explains *why*; competitive analysis shows *what's possible*.

- Analytics: creation rate, skip rate, completion rate, CTR
- Interviews: active creators and frequent viewers
- Benchmarks: Snapchat filters, TikTok editing tools



KEY PAIN POINTS

Where Stories Falls Short Today

Creators rely on third-party apps

Background removal, object cleanup, and advanced edits require external tools — adding friction and drop-off before posting.

Weak link and reel previews

When creators share reel links in Stories, viewers can't see what they're clicking — reducing CTR and engagement.

15-second limit forces workarounds

Longer content gets shared as external links instead of native Stories, breaking the viewing experience.

Viewers skip slow or unclear stories

Loading delays and low-quality content drive skips — a direct retention problem for Instagram.

PROPOSED SOLUTIONS

Three Features to Address Creator Pain Points



AI-Powered Story Editor

Native background removal, smart filters, object cleanup, and quick enhancements — all inside Stories.



Improved Reel & Link Previews

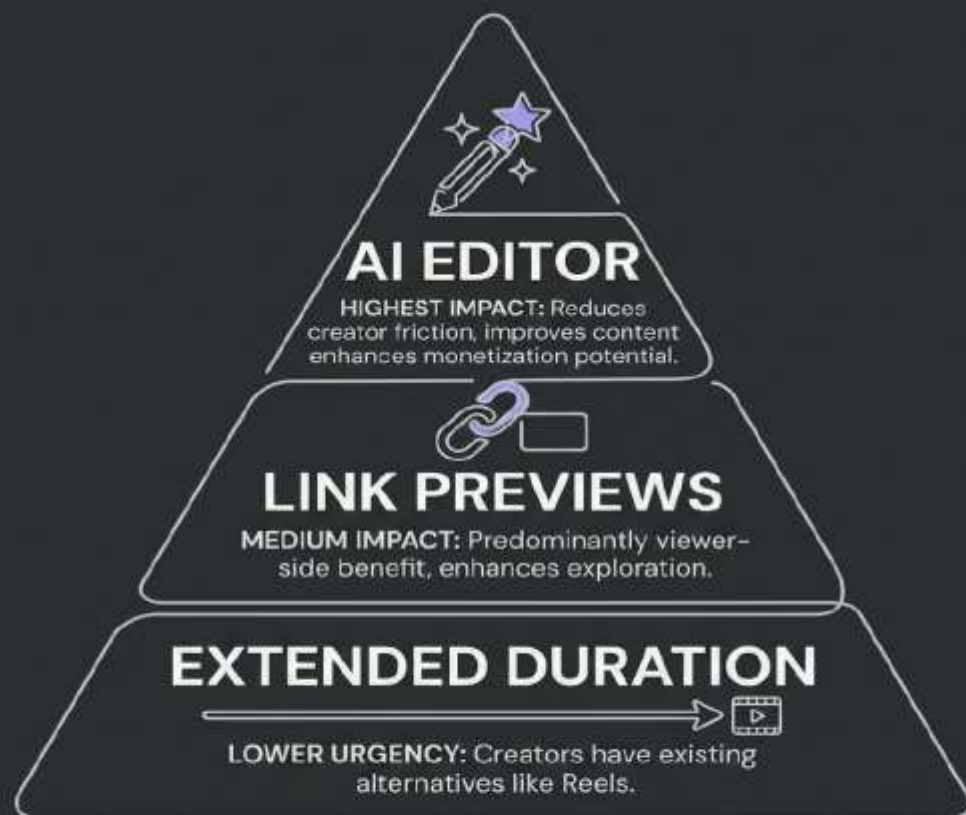
Rich previews for shared reels and links so viewers know what they're tapping before they commit.



Extended Story Duration

Support 30–40 second stories for select use cases, reducing the need to share long content as external links.

Why AI Editing Comes First



Decision Criteria

AI editing wins on **impact, feasibility, and strategic optionality**:

- **Highest creator impact** — directly removes the biggest friction point
- **Quality multiplier** — better edits = better stories = more viewers
- **Monetization path** — premium AI features can become a revenue tier
- **Competitive moat** — Snapchat has filters, but not intelligent editing

③ Link previews and extended duration remain on the roadmap as Phase 2 priorities.

How We'll Measure Impact

DAU

AI Editor Adoption

Daily active users engaging with the AI editor post-launch



Story Creation Rate

Increase in stories posted per creator per day



Completion Rate

Viewer story completion rate — measuring content quality



CTR & Engagement

Click-through rate on stories and viewer reactions

Validation will combine **A/B testing** (comparing editor users vs. control) with **qualitative interviews** to understand behavioral shifts and surface edge cases.

Driving Adoption Across All Users



A Phased Launch Strategy

→ In-App Discovery

Instagram Stories tutorial posted to the official account — like WhatsApp's feature announcement status.

→ Tooltips & Simple UI

A familiar AI icon in the story editor with a short demo video showing background removal in action.

→ Community & Partnerships

Feature creator-made tutorials on Instagram's account. Encourage community examples to inspire repeat usage.